

The Australian Government Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, Senator the Hon. Murray Watt, and state and territory forestry ministers met virtually today for the second time this year.

Ministers discussed the importance of the sector's economic contribution and its delivery of high order environmental outcomes.

Minister Watt shared the news that Australia has joined the Forest and Climate Leaders' Partnership on Greening Construction with Sustainable Wood, which was announced at the UN Climate Change Conference in Dubai (COP28).

- The launch statement highlights the significant role that sustainable forest products can play in reducing emissions in the construction sector, which account for almost 40% of global energy emissions.

The terms of reference for the ministers' future meetings were also confirmed, including five strategic priorities:

- increasing resource security and domestic supply volumes
- expanding the production of timber and wood products
- expanding forestry's contribution to climate change mitigation
- expanding timber industry workforce opportunities and capacity
- continued sustainable management of forests.

Ministers finalised a new workplan that will guide activities through to the end of 2024, with a focus on:

- an expeditious process for the review of the National Forest Policy Statement to ensure it is contemporary and fit for purpose
- opportunities for Indigenous forestry business expansion
- a 50 year outlook for the sector considering the short, medium and long term outlook including recognising the longevity of investment cycles and the contribution of wood products to meeting future housing construction and energy infrastructure needs
- examination of opportunities to expand the industry's participation in carbon markets, and its contribution to climate change mitigation
- review progress in encouraging national research and development capability and innovation, plantation and farm forestry expansion, and increasing workforce capability and participation.

Ministers agreed to meet again by mid-2024.

Ministerial attendees:

- Australian Government (Chair): Senator the Hon Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, and Minister for Emergency Management
- Australian Capital Territory: Mick Gentleman MLA, Minister for Planning and Land Management, Minister for Police and Emergency Services, Minister for Corrections, and Minister for Industrial Relations and Workplace Safety

- New South Wales: the Hon Tara Moriarty MLC, Minister for Agriculture, Minister for Regional New South Wales, and Minister for Western New South Wales
- Queensland: the Hon Mark Furner MP, Minister for Agriculture Industry Development and Fisheries, and Minister for Rural Communities
- South Australia: the Hon Clare Scriven MLC, Minister for Forest Industries, and Minister for Primary Industries and Regional Development
- Tasmania: the Hon Felix Ellis MP, Minister for Resources, Minister for Police, Fire and Emergency Management; Minister for Skills, Training and Workforce Growth, Minister for Racing
- Victoria: the Hon Ros Spence MLA, Minister for Agriculture, Minister for Community Sport, and Minister for Carers and Volunteers
- Western Australia: the Hon Jackie Jarvis MLC, Minister for Agriculture and Food, Forestry, Small Business

Apologies

- Northern Territory: the Hon Nicole Manison MLA, Deputy Chief Minister, Minister for Industry and Trade, Minister for Renewables and Energy, Minister for Mining, Minister for Agribusiness and Fisheries, and Minister for Essential Services (representative attended).

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/forestry-ministers-december-23>